Central Asia as a diplomatic pressure point by making it logistically difficult for Indian convoys to cross into Afghanistan.[149] Such irritants often pushed Indian diplomats to complain to US diplomats about Iran's complicated posture on Afghanistan, and how the US-Iran rivalry was limiting India-Iran collaboration (like in the 1990s) 'to ensure that the Taliban do not return to power'.[150] Tehran and New Delhi were at odds even on the question of US military presence in Afghanistan after 2014 (until the 2015 Iran-US nuclear deal resolved such issues). Iran wanted the US to leave, whereas India wanted to delay the withdrawal. In order to maintain influence on Afghan affairs, Iran not only supported Taliban factions but also allegedly funneled substantial funds into Islamic religious and educational institutions.[151] The Khatam-al Nabyeen Islamic University in Kabul, for instance, has the same curriculum as Iranian madrassas.[152] Staff members of the Academy of Sciences of Afghanistan have been accused of being Iranian spies. Iran's payment to the Taliban militants for killing Americans or destroy US military vehicles has been estimated between US$ 1,000 and US$ 6,000. Much like Islamabad, Tehran ensured that the cost of the US military presence in Afghanistan remained high.[153] Often termed as a marriage of convenience, Iran-Taliban links have not worked in India's favour.[154] India could not, however, 'dump Iran' as put by a senior Indian journalist and retired military personnel in private conversations with Western diplomats.[155] Iran's tactical alliance with the Afghan Taliban raised the question: if born-rivals like Shia Iran and Sunni Afghan Taliban can engage and reach an understanding, then why can India not do the same?

Bleeding heart of Asia

The uncertainty of the Afghan situation after 2010 was reflected in the complex web of regional and international conferences: Berlin (2004), London (2006), Rome (2007), Paris (2008), Moscow and The Hague (2009), and London (2010), the 'Heart of Asia' or Istanbul Process (2011), Bonn Conference (2011), UK-Afghanistan-Pakistan trilateral (2012), and the US-India-Afghanistan trilateral (2012). In India, the MEA and the Confederation of Indian Industries (CII) jointly hosted the Regional Economic Cooperation Conference on